



Posted, Not Passed

A Taxonomy of How Lobby-Noticeboard Entries Come to Read as Settled Rulings

Ingeborg Nwachukwu · Dagny Okafor · Mirela Hanke — School of Continuous Improvement

Background

An inner-suburban apartment block’s lobby noticeboard has run for nine years without a body, a minute, or a moderator — yet residents describe its closed disputes as decided. What turns a taped-up note into a ruling nobody can appeal?

Aims

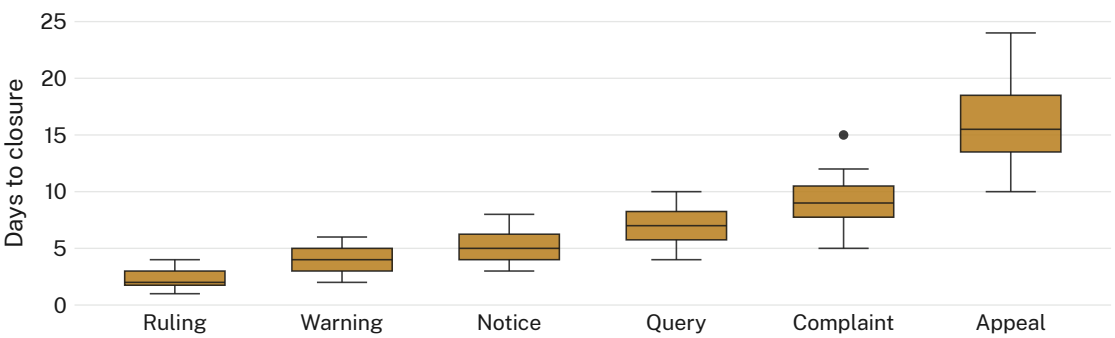
- Build a stable taxonomy of noticeboard entries by adjudicative weight
- Test whether entry type predicts how fast a dispute reads as closed
- Establish whether closure tracks any visible resident authority

Methods

- n = 487 entries · photographed weekly · 4 blocks · 11 months
- open-coded into six types via double-blind thematic coding ($\kappa = 0.79$)
- closure scored against a pre-registered checklist; no body corporate contacted

Results

The six-type taxonomy holds across all four blocks (Fleiss’ $\kappa = 0.74$). Entries coded Ruling close 2.1× faster than entries coded Complaint, despite naming no enforcement mechanism.



Entries coded Ruling close in a median 2 days; entries coded Appeal take a median 16 days, when they close at all (n = 487, 4 blocks, 11 months).

Discussion & conclusions

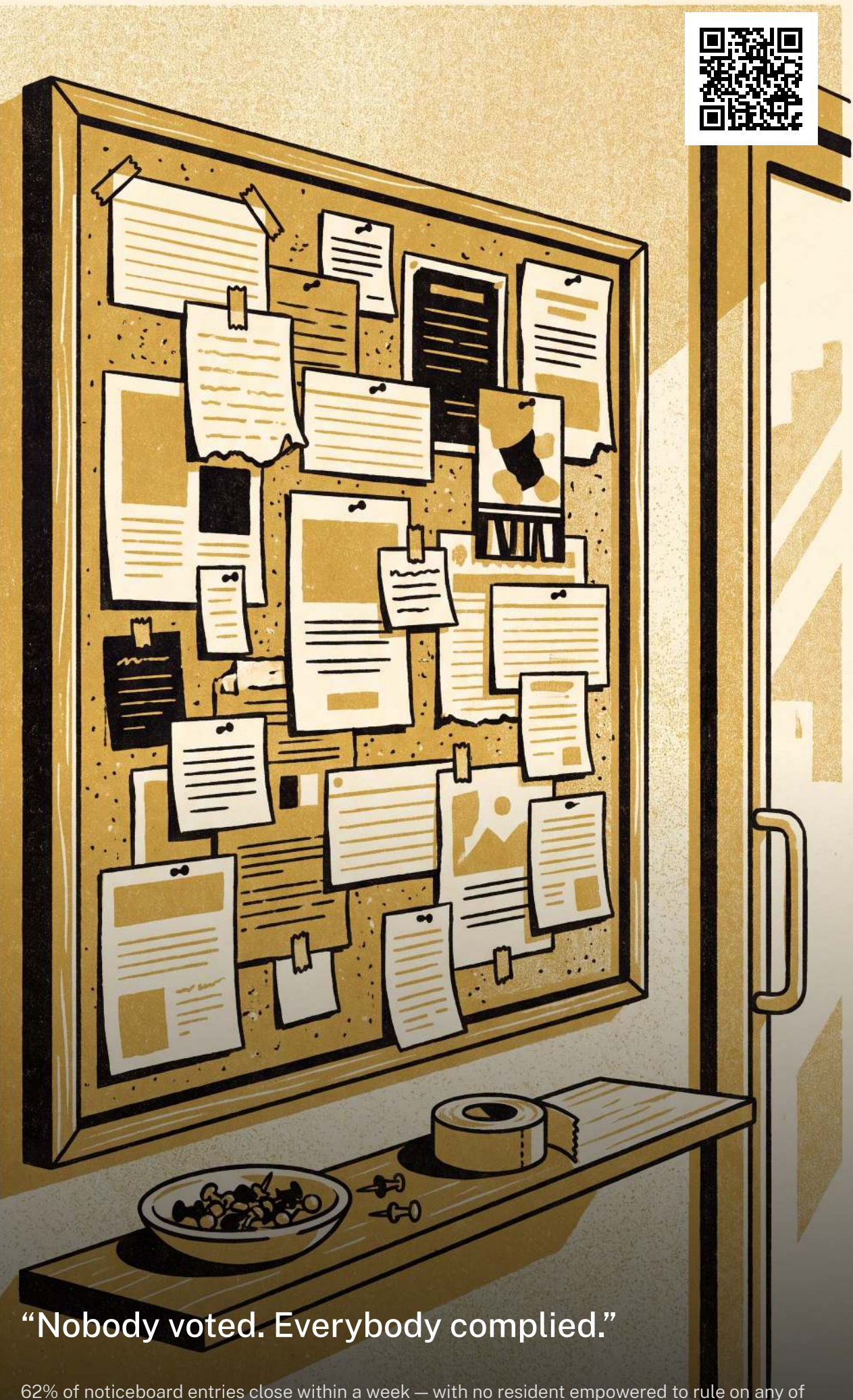
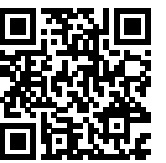
The taxonomy travels between blocks without a shared instruction sheet — coders converged on the same six types independently. Whether an entry reads as a Ruling tracks its phrasing, not the standing of whoever wrote it. Next: testing whether the same six types generalise to noticeboards outside residential buildings.

Selected references

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Human ethics exemption 2026/118; noticeboard entries photographed from common areas only, no unit numbers retained.

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“Nobody voted. Everybody complied.”

62% of noticeboard entries close within a week — with no resident empowered to rule on any of them (n = 487).